

Let's try to lay out Sider's reasoning by isolating the various features of the **traditional doctrine** of heaven and hell that he thinks are inconsistent with the existence of a perfectly good God.

“A certain traditional conception of the afterlife is *binary*. After death one proceeds either to heaven or hell. Heaven is very, very good; hell is very, very bad. There are no possibilities for the afterlife other than heaven and hell, and membership in heaven or hell is never indeterminate or a matter of degree. The problem with the binary conception is that it contradicts God's justice. God must employ some criterion to decide who goes to heaven and who goes to hell. No reasonable criterion would be sharp; any reasonable criterion will have borderline cases. But the binary conception of the afterlife allows for no corresponding fuzziness in how the dead are to be treated. Hell must therefore contain people who are nearly indiscernible in relevant respects from people in Heaven. No just God would allow such a monstrously unfair thing.”

It is part of the traditional doctrine that God decides whether people go to heaven and hell based on certain properties of those people. We will leave open for now what those properties might be; just to have a name for them, let's call them the **relevant properties**.

Badness

Dichotomy

Non-
universality

Divine
control

Justice

Proportion- ality

Continuity

The problem in our present context is that everyone in Purgatory
eventually goes to heaven.

1030 All who die in God's grace and friendship, but still imperfectly purified, are indeed assured of their eternal salvation; but after death they undergo purification, so as to achieve the holiness necessary to enter the joy of heaven.

1031 The Church gives the name Purgatory to this final purification of the elect, which is entirely different from the punishment of the damned.

But then in deciding who goes to heaven, who to hell, and who to purgatory, God is deciding who eventually goes to heaven and who eventually goes to hell. If Continuity and Proportionality are true, this decision must be unjust.



the
paradox of
heaven and
hell



replies to the
paradox



evil & lives
not worth
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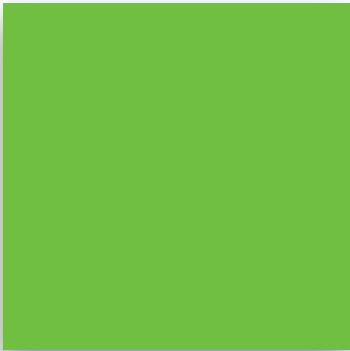
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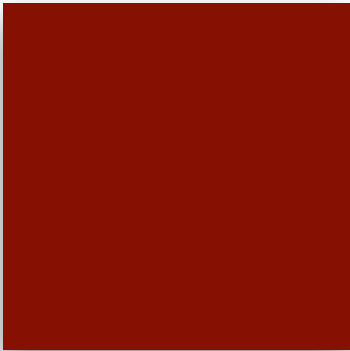












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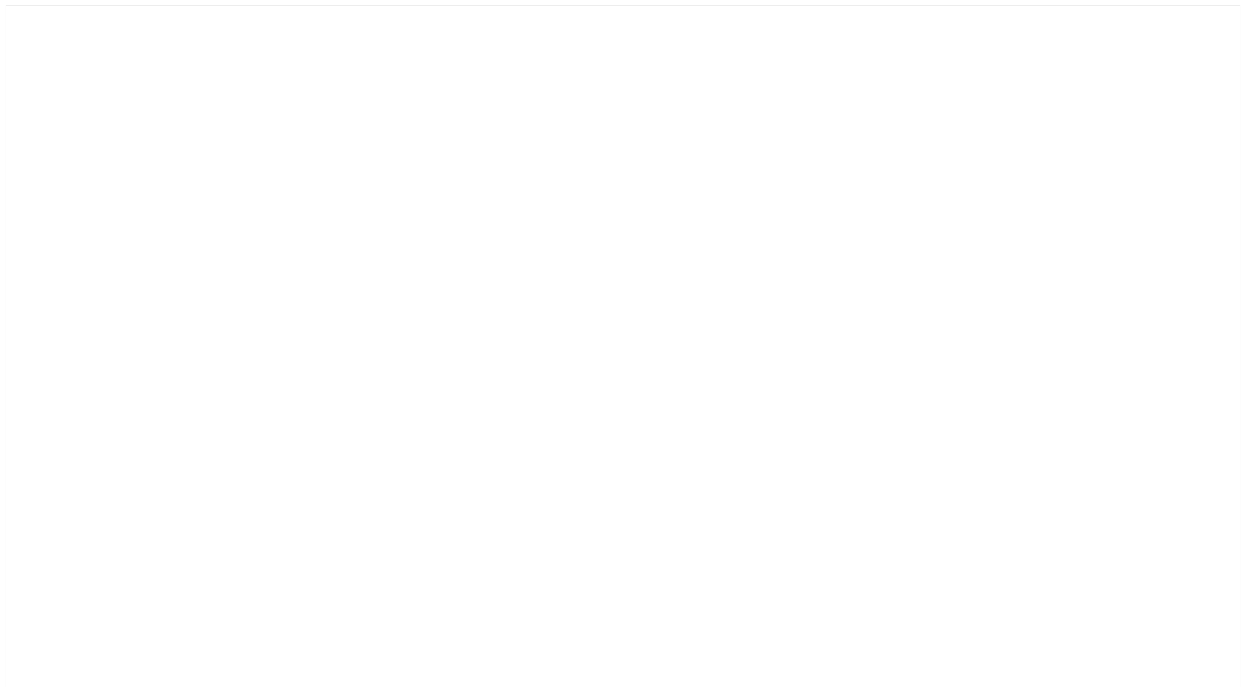
But then in deciding who goes to heaven, who to hell, and who to

decision must be unjust.

putting at bay, God is deciding who eventually goes to heaven and who

describes the kind of view wanted to discuss:

The following passage from the Catechism of the Catholic Church



Judgment. Christ will come "in his glory, and all

1038. The resurrection of all the dead, 'of both the

goats, and he will place the sheep at his right hand,

but the goats at the left.... and they will go away

another as a shepherd separates the sheep from the

all the nations, and he will separate them one from

eternis in die.

into external punishment, but the rights into

the angels with him... Before him will be gathered

just and the unjust,' will precede the Last

One topic often associated with belief in God is the topic of life after death.

perfectly good Good?

Our first question today is: what we are told about life after death by

many of the major monotheistic religions compatible with the existence of a



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the Last Judgment. . . Christ will come "in

this glory, and all the angels with him.

right hand, but the goat at the left... and

Before him will be gathered all the nations,

and the wild sheep are then from another

as a shepherd separates the sheep from the

they will go away into eternal punishment,

goats, and the wild prairie sheep at his

both the just and the unjust," will proceed

but the rights are all in it.

talk of the last judgment wouldn't make much sense.)

got to heaven forever, and some to hell forever. (If not 'forever', then the

judgement on all of us, and on the basis of our life, decides that some of us will

This certainly seems like a picture according to which, after death, God passes

Turned-in showed why it is plausible that respo to the argument from evil

must depend on the possibility of life after death. We will now ask: is the kind of

view of life after death we get here on pain of being perfectly good?



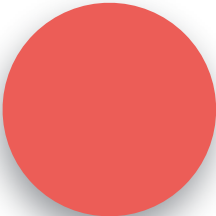






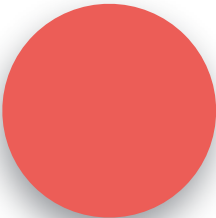
A solid red circle with a subtle drop shadow, centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "evil & lives not worth living" is written in a white, lowercase, sans-serif font, arranged in three lines.

evil & lives
not worth
living





the
paradox of
heaven and
hell



Badness

Dichotomy

Divine
control

Justice

seems to give the defender of the afterlife further main options.



It seems difficult to deny Justice, Badness, or Divine Control. So that



replies to the
paradox

putting at bay, God is deciding who eventually goes to heaven and who

decision must be unjust.

But then in deciding who goes to heaven, who to hell, and who to

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